BATMAN ARKHAM ASYLUM:

A SYMBOLIC COMIC IN A SERIOUS WORLD

Alefiya Malubhhoy

SC3223: Visual Culture: Seeing and Representing (Comics)

October 28, 2021

Batman Arkham Asylum:

A Symbolic Comic in a Serious World

This essay aims to critically analyse Morrison and McKean's (1989) one-shot comic, Batman: Arkham Asylum: A Serious House on a Serious Earth. Through the following essay, I suggest that this comic revolutionizes the comic industry through its use of dense symbolism and abstract art, by textually and contextually subverting the idea of what is orthodox or 'sane', and what is considered preposterous and insane.

Symbolism as Madness

"Born into that other world, of fathomless signs and portents […] and mysterious symbols," claims Amadeus Arkham at the end of his opening memoir, speaking of his mother's illness. The placement of the last phrase outside the panels of his memories (see Figure 1) draw attention to the until-now neglected background of the images which the reader now finds rife with symbols – here, of a ticking timepiece, representing the slow descent into madness. Combined with the fragmented panels that accompany Amadeus' recollections, the comic sets out a tone that is otherworldly and unnatural to superhero comics, presumably even more so to readers in 1989.

He details witnessing his mother as she ate scarab beetles which he now knows are ancient Egyptian symbols of rebirth and, he reflects, was how she attempted to save herself "the only way that made sense to her." With this narration, the act of symbolism, wherein one displaces an idea by representing it through another marker, is established as symptom of mental instability, insanity and madness.

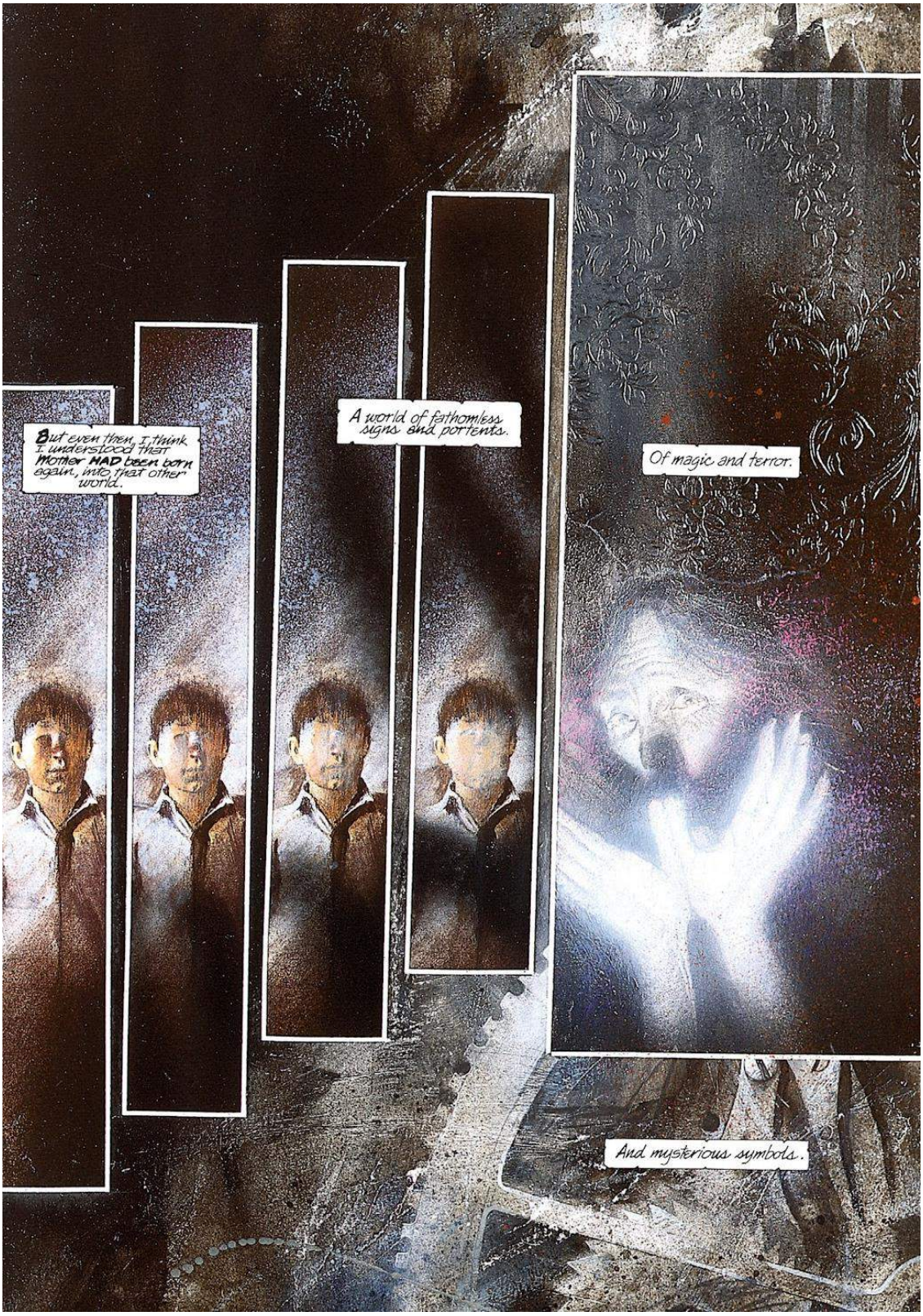


Figure 1. Amadeus' understanding of his mother's mental illness (17).

This theme is compounded across several different mentally ill characters of whom, of course, there is no shortage in Arkham Asylum. These characters are governed by supernatural, almost barbarian and ritualistic logic – indeed, as Arkham puts it, they seem to live in another, darker world, where reality and symbols are one and the same. Morrison even pokes fun at this (perhaps overdetermined) relationship between symbolism and insanity: when Two-Face waxes poetic about the moon being a coin, his fellow inmate exclaims, "Can't I get a decent conversation in this place? You're all insane!" (59; see Figure 2). The panel with the stack of tarot cards through which the reader views the asylum acts as a literary lens, emphasizing that to understand the nature of madness in the book, we must learn its symbolism.



Figure 2. Dent converses with his fellow inmate (59).

Madness is repeatedly characterized as a symptom of symbolism, with the reader's entry to Arkham Asylum itself being an overwhelming double spread page filled with nonsensical mutterings and an array of ancient and ritualistic-looking symbols (see Figure 3). In contrast, the 'outside' world in Gotham, is shown in hazy pencil drawings with sepia overtones, with the panels arranged to look like a roll of film overlaid on the image of the gates of the Asylum (see Figure 4), rendering the outside world, which is free from symbolism and thus is rational, an almost purposeless and lacklustre environment.

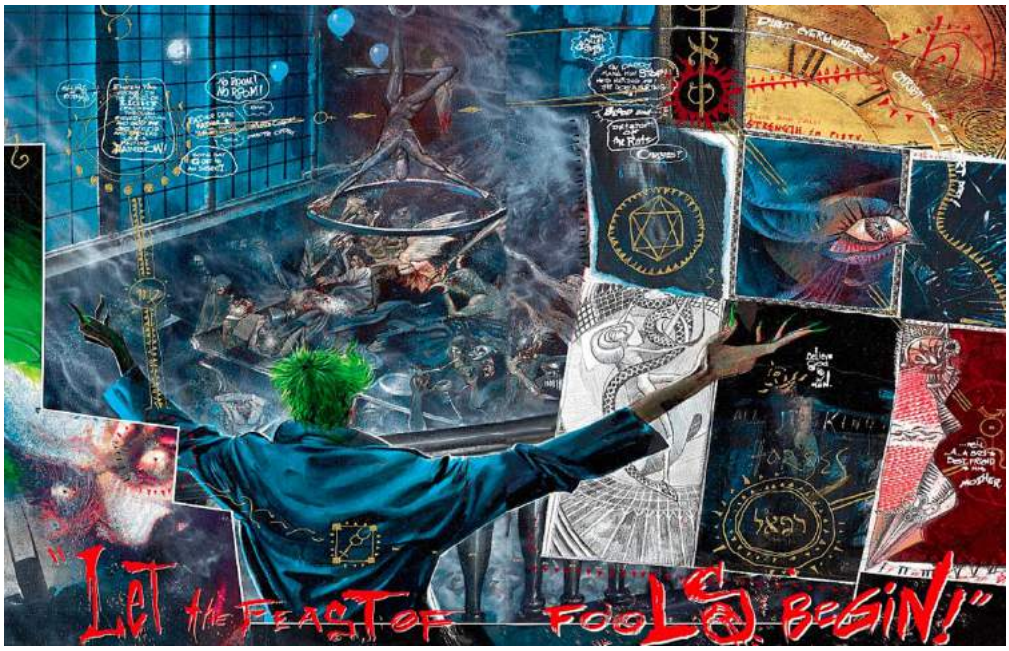


Figure 3. Double spread of when Batman enters an Arkham Asylum overtaken by the inmates (35,36).



Figure 4. Batman learns that the inmates have taken over Arkham Aylum and demand to see him (19).

Martin ‘Mad Dog’ Hawkins, a psychopath rapist-murder and one of Amadeus’ patients, establishes the dangers of insanity that comes with symbolism in the comic. When asked why he destroys the faces and genitalia of his victims, Hawkins replies that the Virgin Mary says it is the best way to get rid of disease (27). The symbol of the Virgin mother is apt – she is pure, virtuous and moral (as subscribed by the patriarchal notion of women being the exemplar of a society’s morals). Hawkins’ impulse to violence is here given justification through his delusions, and the reader is asked to read such an act of symbolism as the sign of such a morally depraved man. Batman’s first instance of insanity is later given through this same symbolism – he associates his mother as the Virgin Mary (see Figure 5).

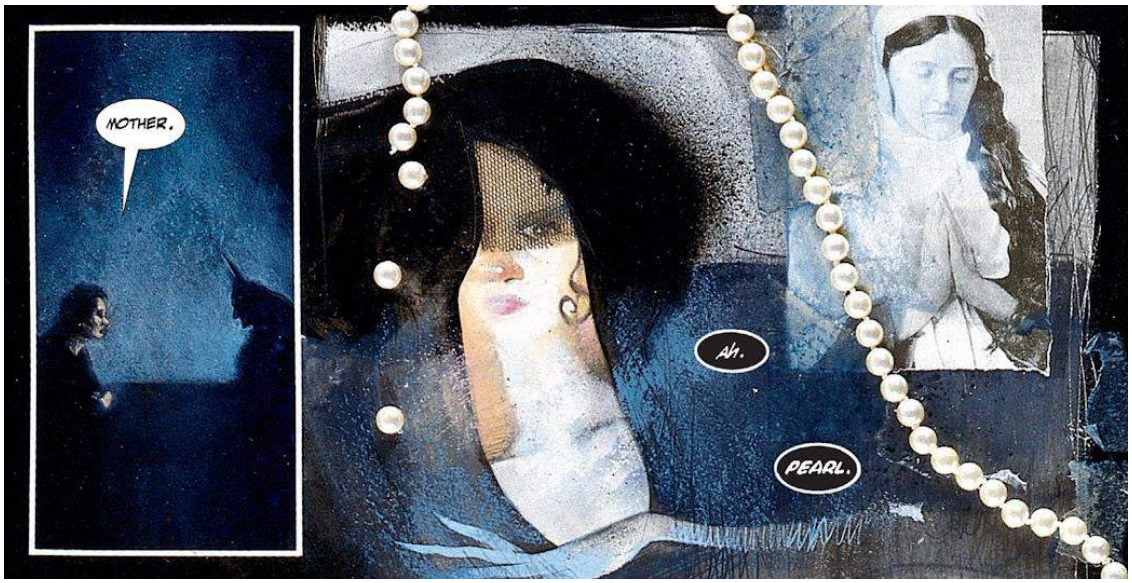


Figure 5. Batman’s mental image of his mother during a word association test is accompanied by a string of pearls and a picture of the Virgin Mary (46).

This also solidifies the symbolism of Batman as the son of the Virgin, the Saviour. The declaration of the comic as “The Passion Play” (4) in the introduction, his injury to his palm in an act of self-crucifixion, his defeat of Killer Croc using the spear from statue of Saint Micheal,

and even the lettering to the ‘t’ in Batman when said by Joker (see Figure 6, Figure 7) point to this allusion. However, instead of a figure of hope, Batman is a figure of despair. Batman must reconcile with this part of himself, since seeing himself as this twisted icon haunts him – it is his personal madness.



Figure 6. The Joker threatens Batman into playing his game of Hide-and-Seek.

The power of religious symbolism is reified through Maxie Zeus, who is convinced that he is the reincarnation of the Greek God of Thunder, Zeus. Maxie’s madness stems, like Batman, from his delusional self-view as an all-powerful mythical figure. However, to sustain this delusion, Maxie requires pilgrimage – he begs for Batman to wait as he offers him unlimited power (77). In much the same way, the symbolic madness of the characters must be dealt with by removing those of subscribe to it – the characters themselves. I suggest that Morrison, as we see in the next section, posits that the only way out of the madness of symbolism is to harness its power and see it to the end.

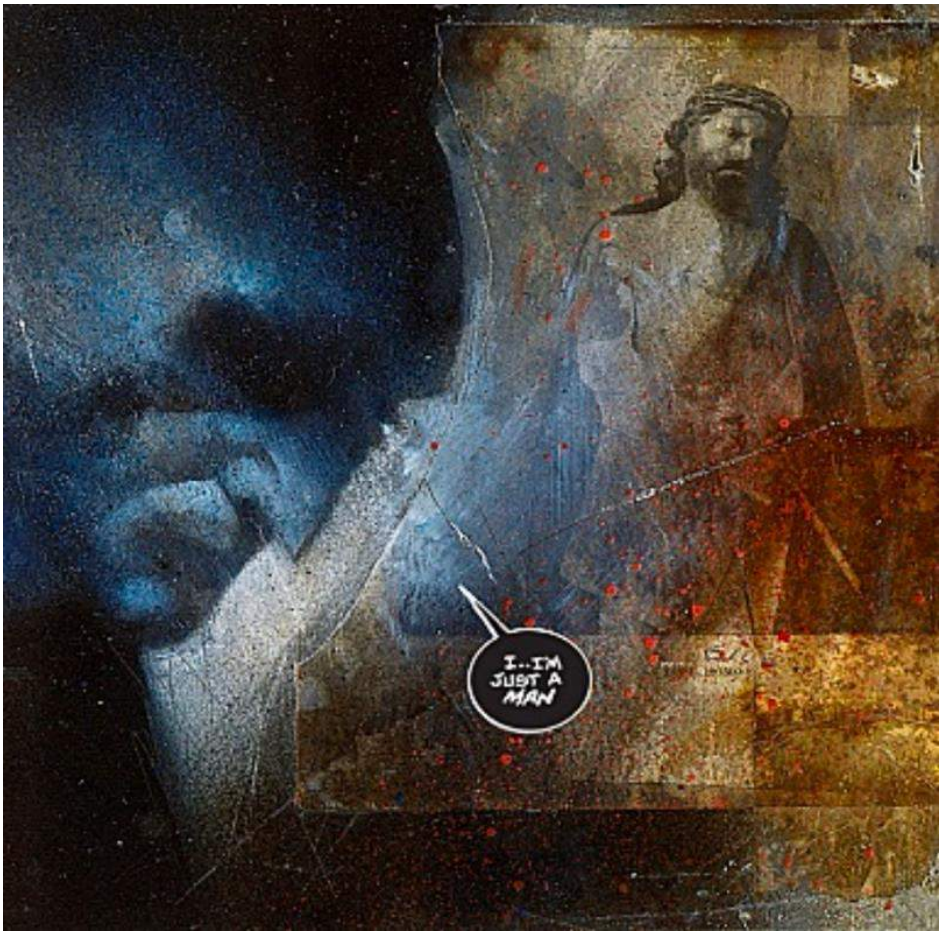


Figure 7. Batman confronts the power of his symbolic dark side.

This dense symbolism was considered a sign of madness even outside of the fictional canon. Comics were historically moral mirrors of society, that reflected social norms and desires (Venkataramani 2021). Thus, they were necessarily straightforward and unambiguous, so as to cultivate a sense of morality. However, this morality was also largely based on national narratives, which were laid down by the government – as seen in figures like Superman and Captain America, who enlisted for war and fought against Communism.

Symbolism, especially the kind that Morrison put forth, was radical in the field of comics and, prior to the release of Arkham Asylum: A Serious House on a Serious Earth, indeed seemed

like madness. The use of symbolism as madness makes a metacommentary on the comic as a form – the radical idea of using symbolism and abstraction in comics to present a depth of story that subverts the norms of what is sane and typical, versus what is insane and radical.

Identifying the Role of Psychology

The subversion of insanity and rationality takes shape as Batman's insanity is slowly uncovered. This revelation is rooted in the subversion of the psychological discipline: psychology, the scientific study of 'curing' mental illnesses, has rendered the characters even more instable – to be sane, one must be insane. Psychology becomes an exacerbation of insanity, and its own method of torture. Joker's aim in subjecting Batman to the word association test is, in fact, to make him suffer by showing him "what it's like to have sticky fingers pick through the dirty corners of his mind" (43).

The nuance between these two apparently exclusive binaries of 'sane' and 'insane' is given voice through, Ruth, the psychotherapist at Arkham Asylum. She elaborates on the case of Harvey Dent, also known as Two-Face, who is characterised by his obsession with duality, especially that of good and evil, and makes all his decisions by flipping a coin. To tackle this obsession, Ruth replaces his coin with a set of tarot cards, to give him a "completely functional set of judgemental faculties that doesn't rely so much on black-and-white" (38). McKean illustrates this black-and-white worldview in pencil (see Figure 8), much in the same way the outside, rational world is drawn (see Figure 4).

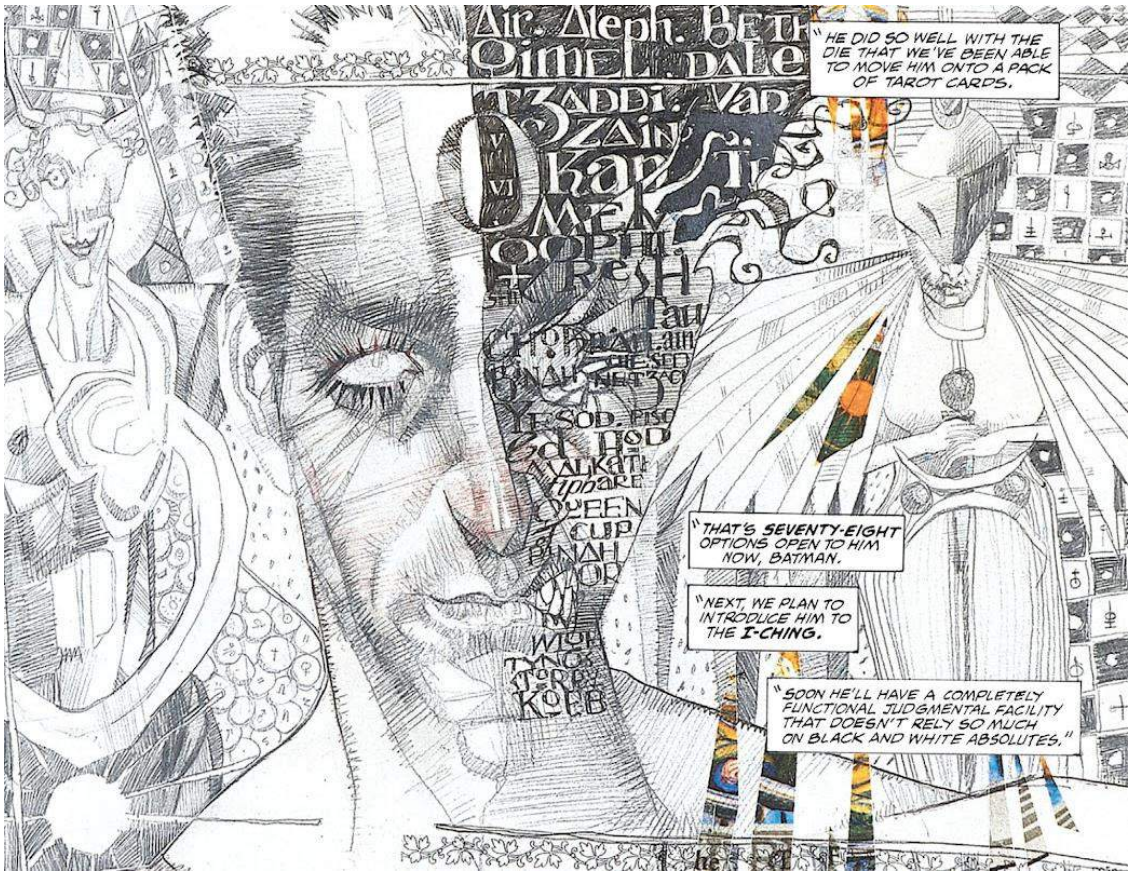


Figure 8. Harvey Dent's morality illustrated (38).

Batman is horrified at this, seeing as Dent cannot even go to the washroom, but Ruth emphasizes, "We must pull down in order to re-build" (39). Thus, insanity becomes an almost necessary condition for mental sanity and stability. This is further compounded when Ruth and Batman begin to discuss the Joker – typically the most chaotic and unstable character in the DC Universe, Ruth destroys this notion as she claims Joker might actually be super-sane (40). This is soon evidenced when Joker compares what he sees in a Rorschach card with Batman: he sees several meanings but they have little to do with the image, while Batman sees a bat – he is not falling into the trap of symbolic madness, but Batman does.

Psychiatry as a gateway to insanity is certainly not a new phenomenon in comics. DC villains and anti-heroes like the Scarecrow, the Mad Hatter, Harley Quinn, and even Amadeus Arkham were all practitioners in the mental health fields prior to their turn to evil. The villainization of this profession may, in part, be due to attempts by psychologists to curb the production of comic books in the 1940s, as a result of the moral panic that the violent stories caused (Hall and Friedman 2020). In response, comics were indeed toned down, particularly for the relatively grittier character of Batman.

By using psychology to further his argument for the conflation of insanity and sanity, Morrison is criticizing both the psychologists and comic creators who continue to portray morality and its portrayal in media as clear-cut binaries. He redefines the complexity of superheroes as moral forces, and indeed paved the way for darker and more realistic portrayals of not only Batman, but other superheroes as well.

Finding Catharsis in Insanity

Ultimately, as predicted by Ruth, insanity paves the way to a sanity, for the characters, the narrative and subsequently the readers themselves. In the first instance, this is clear through Amadeus' discovery of his wife and daughter's bodies. Distraught, he puts on his mother's wedding dress, which to him seems "perfectly, perfectly rational" (64). The use of the lace, not as drawn as a dress but a piece of cloth upon the page itself (see Figure 9), breaks the hypnotic style of McKean's art. It orients the reader in the nonfictional world, while implying that the crux of insanity bestows a clearer worldview – that of reality.



Figure 9. Amadeus Arkham wears his mother's wedding dress after he finds the mutilated bodies of his wife and child (64).

As Amadeus and Batman go on their respective journeys of identity, they both confront their own madness. Batman, no longer the brave hero but a fearful man, faces all his adversaries as he journeys through the Asylum. Amadeus, after exacting revenge for his family's murder, is aimless and lost. In a drug-induced writing, he begins to see multiple symbols that have recurred through the story so far: the two fish, the moon, and the Piscean symbol of trail and rebirth.

As his symbolism (which is also his madness) heightens, the narrative collides into Batman's. So far, the comic juxtaposed the stories of the two men, making the reader connect the dots through motifs. At the crux of the insanity, the narrative is pulled into a parallel combination

(see Figure 10): Amadeus' narration and Batman's actions are finally joined together to make a coherent whole, Amadeus' monstrous dragon that hunts him takes form in Killer Croc. The narrative thus diverges through symbolism and converges at the crescendo of madness, reiterating that sanity is only found through a follow-through of insanity.



Figure 10. Amadeus' distinctive memoir narrates Batman's encounter with Killer Croc.

The characters achieve a catharsis of their trauma and burdens once they give in to this symbolism. Amadeus learns his repressed memory of matricide, and after he is admitted to his own asylum, his act of carving a symbolic binding spell for the bat on the floor of his cell grants him the peace to let go of his life. The absolution of the character and the narrative both is

represented in the use of continuous panels (as opposed to the unfragmented ones earlier in the comic; see Figure 1, Figure 11).



Figure 11. Amadeus Arkham's death (102).

Batman, once he accepts his own cruelty and tendency of violence, and that Arkham Asylum is a madhouse that he feeds, decides that he must show the inmates (and, it is implied,

himself) that he is “stronger than them, stronger than this place” (107). He takes an axe to the front door, to free the symbolic madness of the house. In tearing the asylum’s door down, it seems that batman is also tearing his own walls of fear and aggression down. McKean’s art, which depicts the pipes as arteries (see Figure 12), showcases the symbolic meaning the action has for Batman.

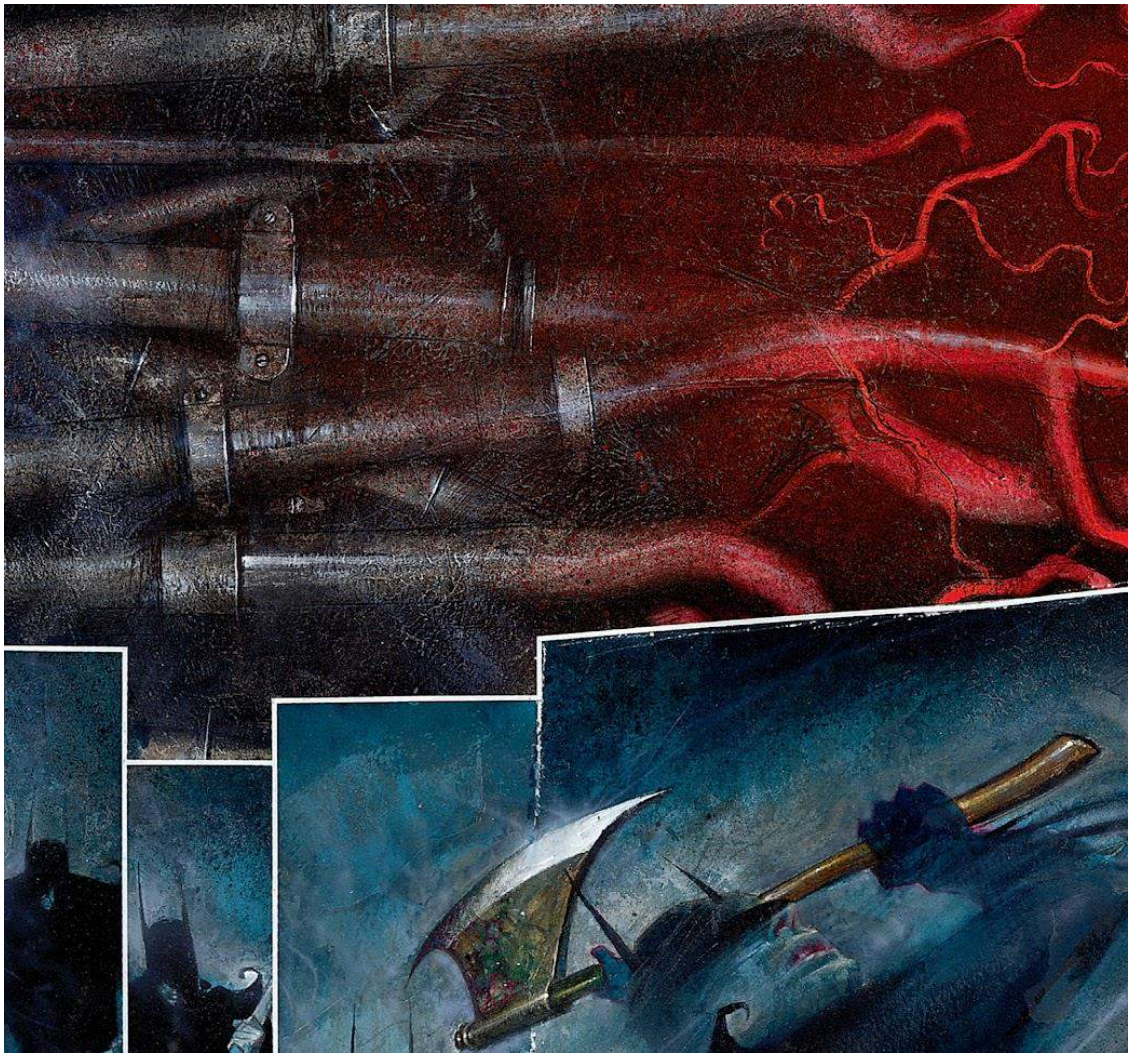


Figure 12. Batman axes the door of the Asylum as an act of catharsis.

Harvey Dent’s reversion to the coin that Batman tosses at him to decide whether he can leave or not is the final nail in this cathartic story – unlike the others, it seems that Dent is

receding back into his exclusive dual choices. He declares that if the coin comes up unscarred, Batman can leave, which it does. However, the final page reveals that the coin had come up on the scarred side, meaning that Dent had let Batman go free.

Dent then looks at his tower of tarot cards, which takes up the whole panel. It was previously seen when his fellow inmate made the humorous remark "You're all insane!" (see Figure 2, Figure 13), obstructing the reader's view of the characters. The tarot cards, the ultimate symbolism, was a veil through which Dent and, by association, the reader viewed the story. In his act of catharsis, Dent flicks the tower of cards, which crumple (see Figure 14), showing the fragility of the symbolic lens. The dissolution of this lens is punctuated by the end of the comic, concluding in the reader's catharsis of their induced insanity through symbols. Thus, Batman: Arkham Asylum subverts the apparently exclusive binaries of sanity and madness through the use of symbolism techniques – in both the fictional and real artistic world.

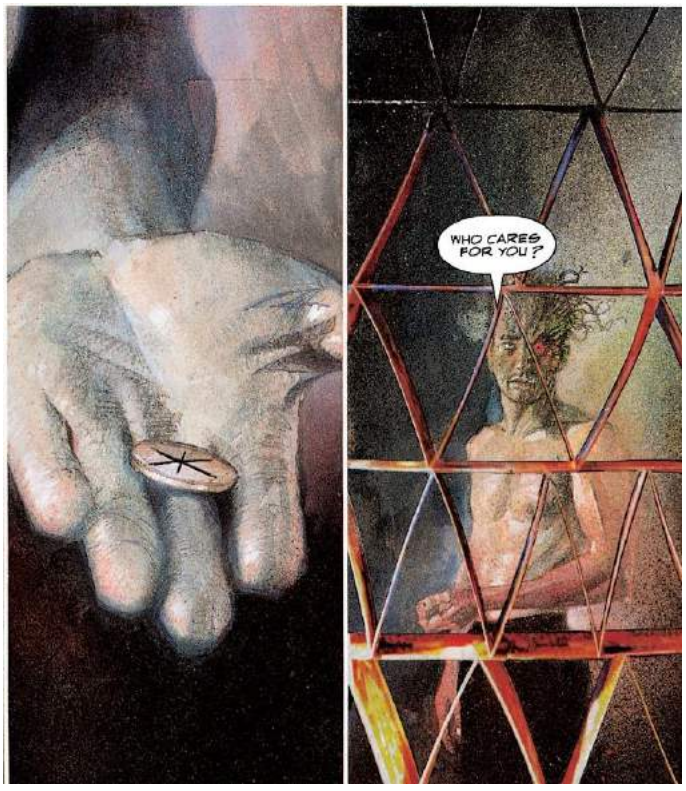


Figure 13. Dent shows the scarred face of the coin, and his dismissal of his tarot cards, having achieved catharsis from his madness.

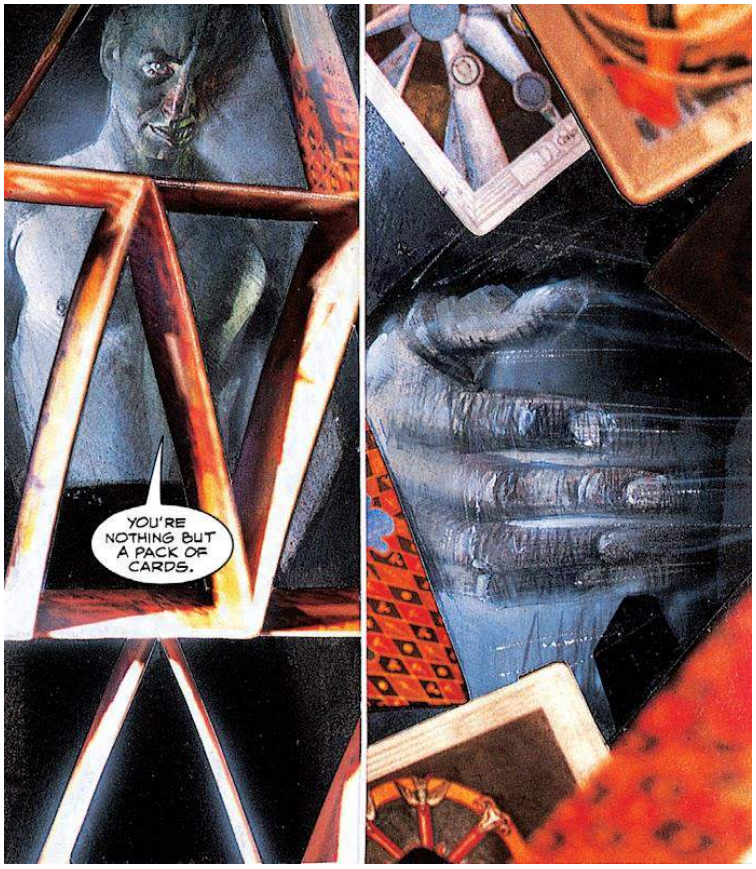


Figure 14. Dent dismantles his tower of tarot cards.

Bibliography

Brown, Jeffery A. 2015. “Batman and Villainy: The Dark Side of the Dark Knight.” In *Batman and the Multiplicity of Identity: The Contemporary Comic Book Superhero as Cultural Nexus*, 157–85. New York: Routledge.

Hall, Ryan C.W., and Susan Hatters Friedman. 2020. “Don’t Laugh at the Comics: A Modern Take.” *Academic Psychiatry* 44 (4): 476–82. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40596-020-01257-2.

McCloud, Scott. 1994. *Understanding Comics*.

Venkataramani, Chitra. 2021. “Week 3: Superheroes + The Language of Comics.”